



Vickers creates a global tank

The Vickers Mark E (or 6-Ton Tank) was designed as a private venture in the late 1920s by a team including designers John Valentine Carden and Vivian Loyd. It became a great export success. It was made in two key variants—the Type A, seen here, with two Vickers machine guns in separate turrets, and the Type B, which had a single turret with an innovative mounting housing a machine gun and a 3-pounder or 47 mm gun. It had riveted armor plates up to 1 in (25 mm) thick on the front, and its suspension consisted of two axles holding double trucks with leaf springs connecting the two sets; when one wheel set was raised, the springs pushed down on the second. An Armstrong Siddeley engine gave it a top speed of 22 mph (35 km/h) on the road.

Vickers exported over 150 Mark Es, and many more were built under licence, in some cases kick-starting the licensee nation's tank production. The Soviet Union bought 15 Type A vehicles and then built their own version, the T-26, in vast quantities, while many of the 17 countries that used the Mark E modified the design to fit their own requirements. The tank saw action worldwide: first in the Chaco War between Bolivia and Paraguay in 1933; in the Spanish Civil War; in the fighting between Finland and the Soviet Union; and in China, Poland, and Thailand.

A Vickers Mark E tank is displayed during trials in Warsaw, Poland in the 1930s, observed by a large crowd.